

The Eight Wastes

DOWNTIME, the eight kinds of waste every Lean practitioner learns to spot.

The First Four

The eight wastes spell DOWNTIME. Defects are anything wrong the first time, like a wrong order or a misspelled name. Overproduction is making more or sooner than needed, like a bakery making twice the croissants it sells. Waiting is anyone or anything idle, which is invisible because nothing seems to be happening. Non-utilized talent, ignoring the ideas of people closest to the work, is the worst because it quietly compounds.

The Last Four

Transportation is moving things further than needed, like a document routed through eight inboxes. Inventory is holding more than the process needs, a hiding place for problems. Motion is unnecessary movement of people. One pharmacy technician walked the same corridor seventeen times in twenty minutes, about seven miles a shift, until a layout redesign cut his walking by 60 percent. Extra-processing is doing more than the customer requires, like adding form fields nobody reads.

Why It Matters

Defects, Overproduction, Waiting, Non-utilized talent, Transportation, Inventory, Motion, Extra-processing. DOWNTIME. Once these eight live in your head, you will confidently see them everywhere. That is exactly the goal.

Remember this

The eight wastes spell DOWNTIME, and once you know them you spot them everywhere.